

PERFORMANCE WORK STATEMENT

Administration for Children and Families

Office of Family Assistance

**Performance Work Statement
For the**

Testing Core Components of Healthy Marriage and Relationship Education Programs

DRAFT

Document Revision History

Mod. No.	Description of Changes	Requested By	Approved By	Date
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Table of Contents

1.0	General.....	4
1.1	Introduction.....	4
1.2	Objective.....	4
1.3	Scope of Work	5
1.4	Background	5
1.5	Type of Contract	12
1.6	Period of Performance.....	12
1.7	Place of Performance.....	12
1.8	Recognized Holidays.....	12
2.0	Specific Requirements/Tasks	12
3.0	Additional Security Requirements	44
4.0	Background Checks	52
5.0	Contractor Quality Assurance.....	53
6.0	Table of Deliverables	54
7.0	Required Travel and Other Direct Costs (ODCs)	61
8.0	Government Furnished Property/Equipment/Information.....	61
9.0	Glossary of Abbreviations and Acronyms.....	61

***Note: as a matter of policy, some agencies require the government to prepare the PWS, the guidance at [FAR 37.602\(a\)](#) stipulates that “a Performance work statement (PWS) may be prepared by the Government or result from a Statement of objectives (SOO) prepared by the Government where the offeror proposes the PWS.”*

Performance Work Statement (PWS)
for the
Testing Core Components of Healthy Marriage and Relationship Education Programs

1.0 General

2.0

2.1 Introduction

The mission of the Administration for Children and Families (ACF) within the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS) is to foster health and well-being by providing federal leadership, partnership, and resources for the compassionate and effective delivery of human services. The mission of the Office of Family Assistance (OFA) is to strengthen families by promoting the dignity of work, supporting marriage, and safeguarding the integrity of public benefits.

The purpose of this task order is to conduct a rigorous, large-scale impact evaluation to test core components for Healthy Marriage and Relationship Education (HMRE) program implementation and to achieve improved participant outcomes.

2.2 Objective

The objective of this contract is to test a prioritized subset of theorized core components using a rigorous study design to assess their impact on HMRE program implementation and participant outcomes. Core components are defined as essential functions and principles, common elements, program components, ingredients, or kernels that define the program and are judged as being necessary to produce outcomes in a typical service setting when implemented effectively.^{1,2} The end product of value of this contract is a final report summarizing the study and synthesizing information across the organizations included in the federal evaluation, including research findings, core components tested, and lessons learned.

Work performed under this contract will:

- Utilize existing memos and reports, to be provided by the Government after contract award, as well as ongoing work that identify and describe theorized core components to inform the impact and implementation study design.
- Refine a draft conceptual model(s) and as needed further refine to reflect the final study design.

¹ Blase, K., & Fixsen, D. (2013). Core intervention components: Identifying and operationalizing what makes programs work. <https://aspe.hhs.gov/report/core-intervention-components-identifying-and-operationalizing-what-makes-programs-work>

² Ferber, T. Sileo, A., & Wiggins, M.E. (2019). Advancing the use of core components of effective programs one pager. [Advancing the Use of Core Components of Effective Programs One Pager - The Forum For Youth Investment \(forumfyi.org\)](#)

- Work with identified programs to assess interest and feasibility, establish memoranda of understanding as applicable, coordinate with finalized sites to refine the research design, and support implementation and data collection.
- Design and carry out rigorous impact studies to determine whether the core components are effective on a number of identified key program outcomes.

2.3 Scope of Work

The Contractor shall furnish the necessary qualified personnel, equipment, materials, supplies, services, facilities, and otherwise do all that is necessary for, or incidental to, the performance of the work set forth below. Offerors responding to this PWS may propose alternative approaches in addition to addressing the tasks as proposed by the government; justification for alternatives (e.g., cost efficiency, etc.) must be provided with any alternatives proposed. Offerors are expected to draw on their own expertise to propose the most effective approach to addressing the tasks. The Contractor is expected to work with the Contracting Officer's Representatives (CORs) to refine the activities and proposed plans once contract is awarded.

Background

Healthy Marriage and Responsible Fatherhood (HMRF) Grant Programs

Since 2006, the Office of Family Assistance (OFA) has administered federal funding for Healthy Marriage and Responsible Fatherhood (HMRF) programs, which aim to strengthen families through healthy marriage and relationship education and responsible fatherhood services. These programs are designed to promote healthy family relationships and economic stability, with the ultimate goal of improving the long-term well-being of children and families. In 2025, OFA awarded a [fifth cohort of five-year grants](#) under this authority.

The HMRF authorizing legislation (42 U.S.C. § 603(a)(2)) and Section 413 (42 U.S.C. § 613) directs the Secretary to assess the effects of these programs on child well-being, family stability, economic mobility, poverty, and related outcomes. This contract will support that mandate by evaluating effective approaches implemented by HMRE grant recipients. Furthermore, this work is particularly important in the current administrative and policy context, which emphasizes strengthening child and family well-being, preventing child maltreatment, and investing in evidence-building to inform federal programs and legislation. Generating actionable evidence on what works, for whom, and under what conditions is critical to ensuring that federal investments in family strengthening programs are effective and aligned with broader child welfare goals.

HMRF Research and Evaluation

To guide HMRF research and evaluation activities, ACF has developed and continues to refine a learning agenda focused on four key areas of inquiry: (1) who participates in HMRF programs, what services they receive, and the outcomes they are working toward; (2) how HMRF programs are implemented in real-world settings, including the resources and supports needed for high-quality implementation; (3) the effectiveness of HMRF programs, including which strategies and approaches produce the strongest outcomes for different populations and contexts; and (4) how data and evidence can be used to strengthen programs and improve outcomes.

A substantial body of research underscores the importance of family stability and relationship quality for child well-being. Studies have consistently found that children living with their married biological parents experience lower rates of maltreatment than those in other family structures, as documented in the Fourth National Incidence Study of Child Abuse and Neglect (NIS-4).³ Research indicates that stable, high-quality marriages are associated with positive child outcomes across emotional, behavioral, cognitive, and physical domains, while family instability is linked to increased behavioral and emotional problems among children. Research indicates that stable, high-quality marriages are associated with positive child outcomes across emotional, behavioral, and cognitive domains, while family instability is linked to increased behavioral and emotional problems; children in stable married-parent families tend to demonstrate better language, academic, and socio-emotional outcomes than those experiencing instability or other family structures.^{4,5}

Prior federal evaluations of HMRF programs have generated important insights but also highlight the need for continued innovation. Large-scale studies such as [Building Strong Families](#) (BSF), [Supporting Healthy Marriage](#) (SHM), and the [Community Healthy Marriage Initiative](#) (CHMI) generally found small or null impacts on key outcomes, such as relationship stability, relationship quality, co-parenting behaviors, and children's building, though some studies with lower-income populations identified more moderate positive effects.^{6,7} Subsequent federal evaluations, including Parents and Children Together (PACT), found improvements in relationship quality, co-parenting, and economic stability in certain program contexts, but mixed effects across outcome domains.⁸

During the third HMRF grant cohort (2015-2020), ACF conducted additional research through B3, [Strengthening Relationship and Education and Marriage](#) (STREAMS), and the [Fatherhood and Marriage Local Evaluation and Cross-Site](#) (FaMLE Cross-Site) project to strengthen understanding of program implementation and effectiveness. B3 tested innovative interventions

³ Sedlak, A. J., et al. (2010). *Fourth National Incidence Study of Child Abuse and Neglect (NIS-4): Report to Congress*. U.S. Department of Health and Human Services.

⁴ Osborne, C. and McLanahan, S. (2007). Partnership Instability and Child Well-Being. *Journal of Marriage and Family*, 69, 1065-1083. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1741-3737.2007.00431>.

⁵ Berger, L. M., & McLanahan, S. S. (2015). Income, Relationship Quality, and Parenting: Associations with Child Development in Two-Parent Families. *Journal of marriage and the family*, 77(4), 996–1015. <https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12197>

⁶ See reports from the Building Strong Families (BSF), Supporting Healthy Marriage (SHM), and the report from the Community Healthy Marriage Initiatives (CHMI) evaluation.

⁷ Hawkins AJ, Fackrell TA. Does relationship and marriage education for lower-income couples work? A meta-analytic study of emerging research. *Journal of Couple & Relationship Therapy*. 2010 Apr 19;9(2):181-91. Bradley RP, Friend DJ, Gottman JM. Supporting healthy relationships in low-income, violent couples: Reducing conflict and strengthening relationship skills and satisfaction. *Journal of Couple & Relationship Therapy*. 2011 Apr 20;10(2):97-116.

⁸ Friend, Daniel, Amy Overcash, Pamela Holcomb, and Heather Zaveri (2020). Pathways-To-Outcomes Snapshots: Tools for Building Evidence for Healthy Marriage and Relationship Education (HMRE) Programs. OPRE Brief # 2020-116. Washington, DC: Office of Planning, Research, and Evaluation, Administration for Children and Families, U.S. Department of Health and Human Services.

within fatherhood programs and generated key lessons on integrating new components and engaging participants. STREAMS examined enhancements to HMRE service delivery and found mixed but informative impacts across outcomes. One program demonstrated improvements in women's relationship skills and attitudes and reductions in unintended pregnancies, while no significant effects were observed for outcomes such as relationship stability, co-parenting, intimate partner violence, or emotional well-being. FaMLE Cross-Site synthesized findings from grant recipient-led evaluations, highlighting variation in impacts across contexts and strengthening evidence on implementation and engagement. Together, these studies reinforced the need to identify specific program components and strategies that drive outcomes, informing subsequent core components research.⁹

More recent federal studies have focused on identifying and strengthening promising program implementation strategies. Studies such as [Strengthening the Implementation of Marriage and Relationship Services](#) (SIMR) and [Strengthening the Implementation of Responsible Fatherhood Programs](#) (SIRF) used rapid-cycle evaluation methods to test approaches to improve recruitment, retention, and engagement. These efforts identified a range of promising implementation strategies, including enhanced case management, tailored outreach, facilitator training, and peer support models.¹⁰

Core Components

Given the variety in HMRF program approaches, populations, and focus areas, there is a need to go beyond determining the “average effects” of HMRF programs. A “core components” framework moves beyond estimating average program effects and instead aims to identify the essential elements of programs that drive outcomes. Core components are defined as essential functions and principles, common elements, program components, ingredients, or kernels that define the program and are judged as being necessary to produce outcomes in a typical service setting when implemented effectively.^{11,12} Core components might be theoretically justified and supported by past research, evidence-informed and empirically established through associations with outcomes, or evidence-based and empirically tested by design.

Focusing on core components offers several advantages. It enables programs to integrate evidence-based elements into a range of service settings without requiring wholesale adoption of a single model; promotes replication and scalability; and supports programs with limited evaluation capacity in incorporating evidence-based practices. It also aligns with federal priorities to build usable, actionable evidence that can inform program improvement and policy decisions.

⁹ See reports from the [Fatherhood and Marriage Local Evaluation and Cross-Site](#) (FaMLE Cross-Site) project.

¹⁰ See reports from the [Strengthening the Implementation of Marriage and Relationship Services](#) (SIMR) and [Strengthening the Implementation of Responsible Fatherhood Programs](#) (SIRF) projects.

¹¹ Blase, K., & Fixsen, D. (2013). Core intervention components: Identifying and operationalizing what makes programs work. <https://aspe.hhs.gov/report/core-intervention-components-identifying-and-operationalizing-what-makes-programs-work>

¹² Ferber, T. Sileo, A., & Wiggins, M.E. (2019). Advancing the use of core components of effective programs one pager. [Advancing the Use of Core Components of Effective Programs One Pager - The Forum For Youth Investment \(forumfyi.org\)](#)

Recent ACF studies, including the [Testing Identified Elements for Success in Fatherhood Programs \(Fatherhood TIES\)](#) and [Core Components of Relationship Education \(C-CORE\)](#) projects, have begun to identify and test core components of responsible fatherhood and relationship education programming, respectively, in HMRF programs. This contract will build on findings from the C-CORE project to support a rigorous impact evaluation of selected core components within HMRE programs funded in the 2025 grant cohort. This project will examine the contexts, populations, and organizational settings in which specific core components are most effective for HMRE programs. By identifying not only what works, but also for whom and under what conditions, this work will support HMRE programs in selecting and adapting approaches that fit their local contexts. The project may also develop practical resources to support the adoption and implementation of effective strategies.

The evaluation will be designed to estimate the causal effects of the proposed core components on participant outcomes, including relationship quality, family stability, and related indicators of adult and child well-being. The study is expected to primarily focus on adult participants served by HMRE programs, while remaining attentive to implications for broader family outcomes. By building on prior descriptive, implementation, and formative research, this study will provide critical evidence on whether and under what conditions specific program strategies improve outcomes for families.

Ultimately, this evaluation will contribute to a stronger evidence base to guide federal investments in family strengthening programs, support continuous program improvement, and advance the broader goal of promoting child well-being and family stability.

ACF's Evaluation Policy

[ACF's Evaluation Policy](#) demonstrates ACF's commitment to conducting rigorous, relevant evaluations and to using evidence from evaluations to inform policy and practice. The five principles of ACF's Evaluation Policy are: rigor, relevance, transparency, independence, and ethics. It is expected that the work described above will be carried out in accordance with these principles.

2.4 Type of Contract

The contract type is Time & Materials.

2.5 Period of Performance

The period of performance of this contract shall be one (1) base period of fifteen (15) months, one (1) optional period of eighteen (18) months, two (2) optional period of fifteen (15) months, and one (1) optional period of thirteen (13) months.

2.6 Place of Performance

The work to be performed under this task order will be performed at the Contractor's address and may include multiple states and localities.

2.7 Recognized Holidays

New Year's Day
Martin Luther King Jr.'s Birthday
President's Day
Memorial Day
Independence Day
Juneteenth

Labor Day
Columbus Day
Veteran's Day
Thanksgiving Day
Christmas Day

3.0 Specific Requirements/Tasks

BASE

Period of Performance: 15 months

Purpose: The Contractor shall engage in a range of activities to: (1) finalize proposed study design and conceptual model(s), (2) develop data collection materials, and (3) begin study site recruitment and selection.

End Products of Value:

- Final approved study design detailing at a minimum identified core components, research questions, conceptual model(s), proposed study sites, proposed study participants, and proposed data sources.

Task 1: Project Management and Team Communication

Effective communication between the Contractor and the federal government, coordinated through the Contracting Officer's Representative(s) (COR(s)), and successful management of the project as a whole are essential to the success of this Service Component and the project more broadly. The need for communication begins at the very start of the contract. **Within five (5) days of contract award**, the Contractor shall initiate communication with the COR and other federal staff to schedule a project orientation to discuss a range of topics, including, but not necessarily limited to, clarification of ACF's interests and objectives for the project, conducting work on an efficient schedule and budget, coordination with other ACF program offices, methodologies to be employed, timelines for early project deliverables, and the challenges anticipated and potential solutions. The Contractor shall send an agenda and any relevant materials to the COR(s) **no less than two (2) working days prior to the discussion**. **Within one (1) week of the discussion date**, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a memorandum summarizing major decisions reached and follow-up issues identified during this discussion.

Ongoing communication is also necessary to ensure successful completion of this Service Component, and should be both verbal (e.g., regularly scheduled conference calls) and written (e.g., monthly progress reports). The Contractor shall propose a schedule for bi-weekly meetings to update federal staff on progress and issues. Key Contractor staff, sub-contractor staff, and/or consultants shall participate as needed to address progress and issues for discussion. The schedule and cadence of meetings may be changed as agreed upon by the COR(s). The Contractor shall submit a proposed agenda for each call **at least two (2) working days in**

advance of the scheduled date to the COR(s) for comment. If there are materials that federal staff will need to review prior to the call date, such materials shall be submitted **at least four (4) business days in advance of the call date**. The Contractor shall submit a summary of meetings to the COR(s) for review and approval **no later than five (5) working days after each regular meeting**.

In addition to the ongoing conference calls, the Contractor shall submit written monthly progress reports throughout the period of the Service Component, which includes the following information: activities completed and progress on each task for the report month, including expenditure data by task, monthly and cumulative expenditures, and the balance remaining. All IT-related expenses shall be highlighted for ease of reporting. The Contractor reports shall include details related to project performance. Monthly progress reports shall be submitted to the COR(s) monthly, **on a regular schedule proposed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s) and before or concurrently with submission by the Contractor of invoices related to that period of performance**.

Subtask 1.1: Work Plan

Within **one (1) month** of the award date, the Contractor shall submit a concise, summary work plan based on the technical proposal, but refined and revised to reflect additional or clarifying information received during the initial discussion with the COR(s) held under Task 1 or via other means. The work plan shall include the timeline for key tasks, activities, and products and identify lead personnel for the activities that reflect the requirements of the project. The work plan shall be a concise, fluid document that is updated as needed. The Contractor shall be prepared to discuss an updated work plan and budget progress **on a schedule determined with the COR(s)** to reflect changes and ensure adherence.

Subtask 1.2: Collaboration and Coordination with Related Projects and Staff

The Contractor shall work with related projects and staff, as needed. These contractors include but are not limited to other federal projects, such as Fatherhood TIES, other entities under contract with HHS, or other government agents, in order to build upon existing work.

Subtask 1.3 Data Inventory

The Contractor shall also develop a data inventory to document information about the data assets created or utilized while executing the contract. The data inventory shall document information about the status, size, and format of the data; whether data are individual or aggregate-level; whether data are identifiable (i.e., contain sensitive or personal information); whether there is associated metadata available including codebooks and data dictionaries; and whether there are limitations on use or disposition described in data use agreements or informed consent forms. The data inventory shall be regularly updated at least every six (6) months through the period of performance, or more frequently as directed by the COR.

Task 2: Transition-In Activities

The Contractor shall be responsible for coordinating with the COR(s) and other government-designated entities, including prior contractors and consultants, to ensure a smooth transition of

all relevant project materials, data, and knowledge generated under previous task orders. This includes, but is not limited to, prior research findings, reports and memoranda, conceptual models, data collection instruments, analytic plans, datasets (as permitted), documentation, and any other resources necessary to support successful execution of this contract.

The Contractor shall receive all Government-furnished or Government-funded materials, including data and associated documentation, in accordance with applicable data rights and privacy requirements, and shall use these materials to inform and build upon prior work. This includes incorporating findings and products from related projects (e.g., C-CORE) as directed by the COR(s).

The Contractor shall document transition activities and provide regular updates during scheduled project management meetings (Task 1).

At the direction of the COR(s), the Contractor shall carry out transition-in activities, which may include:

- Developing and submitting a Transition-In Plan for COR(s) approval, outlining the approach to receiving, reviewing, and integrating prior materials and coordinating with relevant entities;
- Implementing all COR(s)-approved transition activities;
- Participating in transition meetings and providing agendas, materials, and summaries of discussions, including key decisions and follow-up actions.

The Contractor shall participate in training or knowledge transfer sessions with HHS staff, prior contractors, or other designated entities, as needed, to support a smooth transition and ensure full understanding of prior work, data systems, and evaluation approaches. The Contractor shall be prepared to receive and incorporate such materials and training within a timeframe approved by the COR(s).

All transition-in activities shall be conducted on a schedule proposed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s), with the goal of ensuring continuity, minimizing disruption, and enabling timely progression into study design and implementation activities.

Task 3: Plan and Implement Active Engagement Approach

For the purposes of this solicitation, active engagement is defined as the intentional involvement of individuals and groups with a stake in the outcomes of the research or evaluation. Active engagement shall occur across all relevant phases of the project and is intended to improve the quality, rigor, and relevance of ACF-funded work and support the use of findings. ACF seeks input from individuals with practice-based and empirical expertise to inform key activities, including refining conceptual models, developing research questions, selecting measures, providing evaluation technical assistance, supporting implementation, contextualizing findings, and informing external communications.

The Contractor shall develop and implement an active engagement approach that maximizes meaningful opportunities for input across all phases of the project lifecycle. Engagement strategies may include, but are not limited to, co-creation, community-based participatory approaches, advisory groups, and targeted consultation. Opportunities for input shall be incorporated, as appropriate, from study design through dissemination.

Groups and individuals to be engaged may include, but are not limited to, service providers; program participants; intervention developers; subject matter experts; federal, state, tribal, and local program staff and leadership; community members; and researchers and practitioners in relevant fields.

All active engagement activities shall be conducted in accordance with the ACF Evaluation Policy and must preserve the independence and objectivity of the evaluation. Input shall be obtained transparently and incorporated as appropriate, while ensuring that evaluation design, conduct, analysis, and reporting remain free from undue influence or bias.

The Contractor shall tailor and implement this approach for the HMRF context, including engagement with grant recipients, federal partners, and field experts. Active engagement shall be ongoing throughout the project to ensure that findings are relevant, feasible, and useful for informing policy and practice.

Subtask 3.1: Active Engagement Plan

No later than one (1) month after contract award, or on a schedule determined with the COR(s), the Contractor shall provide a plan for active engagement in project tasks and deliverables. To accomplish the goals of including meaningful and appropriate active engagement while upholding the principle of independence in ACF sponsored evaluations, the plan should begin with a clearly articulated rationale for the Contractor's approach to active engagement to guide the entire project and achieve its purpose. This rationale shall guide engagement across all tasks and any options. The approach to active engagement shall describe the reason for inclusion of the individuals and groups proposed to be engaged, how and when they will be engaged, and how input will be addressed and incorporated to achieve the purpose of the study.

The plan should follow from this approach and:

- delineate the project tasks and activities where active engagement will occur;
- demonstrate how active engagement in these tasks and activities will meet specific goals of this project;
- identify potential individuals and groups who may be involved in the active engagement and indicate why or to what end they will be engaged, how they will be engaged, and the timeline for when the project plans to engage them;
- describe the budget considerations associated with the proposed active engagement; and
- delineate how the plans for active engagement will be refined throughout the project.

Additionally, the plan should include explicit discussion of how independence of research and evaluation findings will be protected from both the appearance and reality of bias throughout the planning for and execution of active engagement. If appropriate, a Memorandum of Understanding with some individuals and groups may be warranted, particularly in high-stakes evaluations or sensitive relationships. The contractor's plan shall be updated **throughout the project as necessary** to document the decisions and agreements made around areas of active engagement.

Groups with which to actively engage shall include (but are not limited to) the following:

- HMRE program practitioners
- Previous or current participants in HMRE programming
- Researchers and evaluators, particularly those with experience with core components methods
- Federal partners working with HMRE and related or relevant programs.
- HMRE curriculum developers
- Technical assistance providers for HMRE programming

The Contractor shall coordinate with and incorporate findings and discussions summarized by other projects, such as Fatherhood TIES, C-CORE, SIMR/SIRF, and PACT. Other relevant projects may be identified by the COR(s) and/or the Contractor.

Subtask 3.2 Implementation of Active Engagement Activities

The Contractor shall implement all activities in the COR-approved Active Engagement Plan in Subtask 3.1. The Contractor shall submit any draft and final deliverables in the Active Engagement Plan to the COR for review and approval on a schedule proposed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s).

Task 4: External Communications

Subtask 4.1 Develop External Communication Plan

ACF wants information about and findings from its research and evaluation projects to be shared with relevant audiences throughout the course of the project. The Contractor shall develop an external communication plan for this project that describes:

- Overarching project communication goals;
- Key types of information the project expects to convey (e.g. project site selection; project implementation findings; interim impact findings; etc.) and projected timeline for when this information will be available;
- Key audiences for different types of project information;
- A detailed strategy – including proposed products – for communicating specific information to specific audiences;
- Communication resources (e.g. staff, budget);

- Metrics that will be used to gauge the impact of communication activities and a plan for collecting and analyzing metrics and applying insights;
- A schedule for revisiting the communication plan throughout the project's duration, tracking progress on the plan, and revising as necessary; and
- A schedule for COR(s) review of communication deliverables.

Examples of external communication products may include, but are not limited to:

- Introductions or announcements of project and project participants
- Project newsletters
- Conference presentations
- Interim and final reports
- Briefs
- Special topics reports
- Briefings to ACF and/or other relevant policy officials or program administrators
- Scholarly journal articles
- Technical papers/memoranda
- Videos
- Data visualizations
- Infographics
- Social media content
- Other multimedia content

ACF encourages innovative approaches to research communication and outreach. To the extent possible, the Contractor shall apply modern best practices to the development of all external communication products. All deliverables shall be compatible with the ACF website and other communication platforms. Before work begins on web-based or other multimedia content the Contractor shall consult with the COR(s) and other relevant ACF communications staff to ensure computability.

The Contractor shall ensure that *all* external communication products meet or exceed Section 508 compliancy standards. Materials needed to make multimedia content 508 compliant, including but not limited to .srt caption files and alt text, shall be delivered to the COR(s) as a component of the final deliverable package. At a minimum all written deliverables must pass an Adobe Acrobat accessibility check, and the Contractor shall deliver verification of this check to the COR(s) as a component of the final deliverable package. For written deliverables the Contractor shall use a clear and consistent heading and tagging scheme, provide human-generated descriptive alt text for all images and graphics, use simple formatting in tables (i.e. no

merged cells, multiple simple tables vs. complex tables). Any deliverable submitted to the Contractor that is not 508 compliant is subject to rejection or to be returned to the Contractor for remediation.

The contractor shall ensure that *all* written components of deliverables meet federal plain language guidelines (<https://plainlanguage.gov/media/FederalPLGuidelines.pdf>). Plain language is a priority for ACF to ensure that deliverables created are clear, accessible, and useful to relevant audiences. Any deliverables that do not adhere to the Plain Language Guidelines will be returned to the Contractor for revision.

Reports exceeding 15 pages shall include a 1-2 page overview section written in plain language, highlighting the key findings. Longer reports may also require an executive summary, at the direction of the COR(s). Highly technical materials shall usually be placed in appendices. In addition, the Contractor shall adhere to ACF's requirements regarding the publication of documents, including formatting, inclusion of the logos, report number, and inclusion of other important information. Documents that do not meet ACF's guidelines will not be approved for release. The COR(s) will provide these guidelines to the Contractor upon award.

ACF reserves the right to request that the Contractor submit contract deliverables for independent or external review. This request may come at the time of development of the external communication plan or as products are developed. If independent or external review of deliverables is requested, the COR(s) will provide additional information about the structure and nature of this peer review.

The Contractor shall submit **a draft external communication plan to the COR(s) on a schedule determined in consultation with the COR(s). A final plan shall be submitted within three weeks of receipt of feedback from the COR(s).** Deviations from the final plan require prior approval of the COR(s).

Subtask 4.2: Develop Project Description

The Contractor shall develop a brief, one- or two-page Project Description for use by the Contractor and ACF that provides an overview of the project and communicates the purpose of the project. The first draft of the project description shall be submitted to the COR(s) **no later than one week after the project orientation.** The Contractor shall revise the draft project description based on COR(s) feedback and shall submit a revised document **on a schedule proposed by the contractor and approved by the COR(s).** The Contractor shall update the project description over the course of the contract at the request of the COR(s) in order to ensure that the project description adequately provides up-to-date information about the project.

Subtask 4.3: Cover Sheet for all Written Deliverables

To help support ACF's understanding of how documents are produced, the Contractor shall develop a document coversheet for use when submitting drafts of deliverables prepared for publication. The cover sheet shall identify, at minimum, the following information:

- The version of the document (draft, first round of revisions, etc.)
- The lead authors of the deliverable
- Additional staff involved with editing or reviewing the document

- The level of effort from each staff person
- Whether the deliverable is consistent with the guidelines reflected in the Clear Communication Checklist (attached)

Subtask 4.4: Ongoing External Communication Activities

Ongoing and continuous activities are essential to a strong communication approach for the Base and the project more broadly. The Contractor shall undertake activities necessary to meet the goals of the project's external communication plan. The nature and frequency of these activities will be determined in communication with the COR(s) based on the approved communication plan. The Contractor shall submit draft and final external communication products to the COR(s) for review and approval **on a schedule proposed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s).**

Task 5: Finalize and Refine Research Design Plan

As part of Task 3, bidders will be provided with draft memos, reports, and other background materials that can be used to inform a proposed approach to test the recommended components or combination of components (see Attachments XYZ). The successful awardee will receive all approved foundational ACF reports and memos to inform the refinement and finalization of that proposed research design. This will include a report with recommended core components for prioritization and accompanying memos summarizing the systematic review and meta-analysis findings.

Subtask 5.1: Finalize Core Components for Testing

The Contractor will receive a preliminary list of recommended core components for testing that were identified and prioritized through a systematic review conducted by the C-CORE project and a subsequent meta-analysis.

The Contractor shall make final recommendations that include proposed outcomes for evaluation and proposed research questions that address the effectiveness of the components. It is possible that the recommendation will be a series of components or a single component. Final recommendations shall be submitted **within 1 month of award, or upon a schedule to be determined in consultation with the COR(s).** Components and conceptual models (Subtask 5.2) may also be shared through discussions with the COR(s), during kick-off discussions, and/or through a preliminary draft of the Research Design Memo.

Subtask 5.2: Finalize Conceptual Models

The Contractor should plan to develop conceptual models of the theories of change related to the approved priority components. The conceptual model(s) is intended to describe the inputs and activities for HMRE programs; define target mechanisms or to be measured; and link to specific the outcomes theorized to improve after the end of program services and attributed to a particular core component or combination of components based upon an explanatory theory or theory of change. As with Subtask 4.1, the Contractor may receive a preliminary draft of potential conceptual models related to the identified components. Each conceptual model shall include contextual information, including population characteristics and implementation factors (e.g.,

program setting), to demonstrate how different contexts may moderate effects of the components. Ideally these models should be finalized in partnership with identified sites to ensure that the study design and final research questions align with their specific programs.

Final conceptual model(s) will be submitted **within 1 month of the finalized recommendations of components (subtask 5.1) for test(s) being submitted, or upon a schedule to be determined in consultation with the COR(s).**

Subtask 5.3: Finalize Research Design

The Contractor shall develop research/evaluation design plan(s) to test the recommended components or combination of components identified in subtask 5.1. The research design plan(s) shall focus on research questions that can feasibly be assessed, data for addressing research questions, approaches to data collection, and guides for ensuring cohesion to research design. The research design plan(s) will draw from the work conducted in subtask 5.1, 5.2, and 8.1.

For each approved conceptual model, the Contractor shall develop a research/evaluation design that supports assessment of impacts of each core component or selected combinations of core components. All research/evaluation design(s) must rigorously compare core components (and/or combinations of core components) against an equivalent and systematically varied comparison group or condition. (Statistical comparability would need to be able to be established between the program group and the comparison group before the test is implemented.)

In each research/evaluation design, the Contractor shall provide sufficient detail on the sample(s)/settings(s) (e.g. schools, community centers) needed to execute and evaluate each conceptual model appropriately. This includes but is not limited to information about target populations, representativeness, and sample size. The Contractor shall include power analyses, including the Contractor's assessment about the necessary size of the sample to detect significant differences in outcomes, and if necessary, differences between subgroups on key outcomes. The final research design should also include proposed timelines and a high-level proposal of proposed data collection methods to be used and finalized under the Data Collection Plan (Task 6).

Within 10 months of award of contract, or upon a schedule to be determined in consultation with the COR(s), the Contractor shall submit the research/evaluation design plan(s) to the COR(s) and shall submit a revised memorandum **within two weeks of receipt of comment.**

Task 6. Develop Data Collection Instruments and Protocols

The Contractor shall develop the data collection instruments and protocols necessary to address research questions for each refined evaluation design approved by the COR(s).

Subtask 6.1: Identify constructs and measures

For each evaluation, the Contractor shall develop a comprehensive list of all constructs recommended to be measured. The Contractor shall cross-walk all constructs with the key

research questions and data sources and shall justify why the constructs will satisfactorily answer the relevant research question(s).

The Contractor shall recommend a comprehensive list of all measures/questions. The Contractor shall cross-walk all measures/questions with the constructs recommended and shall justify why the measures/questions are the best options for measuring the constructs. The justification may include past evidence of each measure's psychometric properties (including, but not limited to: reliability, validity, and sensitivity to change), populations on which it has been normed and used, its appropriateness for use with the target population of the evaluation, or an assessment of its suitability for longitudinal data collection with the population under study. Additionally, the Contractor should consider utilizing existing surveys and data collection efforts the HMRE grant recipients already participate in through the nFORM data system.

Subtask 6.2: Develop Data Collection Instruments and Protocols

The Contractor shall integrate all measures/questions into data collection instruments and protocols. The Contractor shall cross-walk all instruments with measures/questions, constructs, and research questions, and, where appropriate, provide justification for decisions made in developing instruments. The Contractor shall develop protocols for all data collection instruments (including protocols for simple, straight-forward instruments) and shall justify why the protocols developed are the best options for addressing the research questions. For all evaluation designs, the Contractor shall consider whether common data elements shall be collected across some or all sites. The protocols shall include processes for obtaining consent and assent, as appropriate.

Subtask 6.3: Develop Data Collection Memo

At the direction of the COR(s), for each evaluation, the Contractor shall produce a memo or memos on the recommended:

- Constructs;
- Measures/questions; and
- Data collection instruments and protocols, including timelines.

Within one month of the approval of each research/evaluation design, the Contractor shall submit the final (in the case of multiple memos) or sole (in the case of a single memo) memorandum and shall submit a revised memorandum **within two weeks of receipt of comments**. As necessary, the Contractor shall enter into agreements to access the proposed data including nFORM and any other data sources.

Subtask 6.4: Pre-testing Data Collection Instruments and Protocols, and Refinement

The Contractor shall conduct a pre-test of the data collection instruments for length, clarity, and appropriateness of protocol for data collection (e.g., obtaining informed consent from participants, use of computer assisted or web-based data collection procedures). Participants shall be representative of the populations being served in each identified study site. As necessary,

the Contractor shall refer to Base Task 9, Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Clearance for Data Collection and Institutional Review Board (IRB) Approval.

Within two weeks of completion of any pre-testing, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a memorandum describing the pre-test, its results, and recommended adjustments to data collection instruments and protocols; the Contractor shall revise the memorandum **within two weeks of receipt of comment**.

Task 7: Site Selection

Subtask 7.1: Finalize Site Selection

The Contractor shall consider the necessary characteristics of organizations or agencies needed to support the proposed study design and propose criteria to assess sites for inclusion.

Considerations should include, but are not limited to:

- community readiness (e.g., community awareness/knowledge of identified implementation issues, community buy-in, etc.)
- contextual environment (including policies, local political environment, other local context)
- organizational priorities and goals, including willingness to engage in evaluation activities and methods
- implementation challenges identified by the organization
- amenability and interest of programs to adopting the component(s) to be tested as identified in Subtask 4.1
- existing data infrastructure and capabilities
- target population
- program capacity
- operational information (e.g., monthly enrollment levels, level of active participation)
- assessment of reasonable placement of random assignment

The Contractor will receive a preliminary list of site recommendations and shall use other available information (grant recipient applications, websites, etc.) as well as discussions with federal staff (or other knowledgeable persons) and directly with organizations to refine the list of recommendations. The Contractor shall obtain COR(s) approval prior to contacting any individuals or organizations.

The Contractor shall submit recommendations for a final set of organizations and information to support their recommendations to the COR(s) **no later than forty-five (45) days from contract award, or upon a schedule determined in consultation with the COR(s)**.

Subtask 7.2: Establish Agreements with Selected Programs/Organizations

Prior to contacting and reaching agreement with the organizations and **no later than one (1) month** after the COR(s) has approved the inclusion of the organization, the Contractor shall submit a draft Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) outlining the roles and responsibilities of the involved parties and key elements proposed, including expectations, financial support, and

performance benchmarks. The Contractor shall address comments received from the COR(s) **within two (2) weeks**.

ACF expects that organizations participating in this study will require financial support to meet evaluation requirements (e.g., additional staff or staff labor hours to meet data collection requirements or recruitment of higher number of individuals, etc.). All decisions regarding financial support will be made by ACF on case-by-case basis, and the amount will be arrived at in consultation with the COR(s).

Individual MOUs tailored to each organization shall be submitted to the COR(s) for review and approval prior to submission to each organization, and any comments from the COR(s) shall be addressed. The Contractor shall submit MOUs that have been reviewed and agreed upon by the organizations recommended for inclusion **within two (2) months** after the organization was approved to be included and sufficiently in advance of the proposed start of the study. The Contractor shall inform organizations that ACF must review and approve the negotiated MOU before it is to be formally signed by the Contractor and the organization representative.

Subtask 7.3: Develop Evaluation Implementation Monitoring Plan

The Contractor shall develop criteria and benchmarks to monitor the status of the evaluation for ongoing assessment of:

- Implementation of the component(s) to be tested (e.g., fidelity of program component implementation, levels of active participation among enrollees, etc.); and
- Implementation of the evaluation (e.g., sample enrollment, baseline data collection, maintenance of random assignment/contamination, etc.).

Additionally, the Contractor shall include details about their planned technical assistance approach to support the evaluation.

The Contractor shall also develop a data collection tool(s) appropriate for this kind of evaluation to capture key implementation variables including enrollment, attendance, dosage, fidelity to the component(s) (and the fidelity to altered component(s), e.g., as appropriate for the design) and others at the level of the organization. The tool(s) must permit monitoring the flow of information and produce periodic reports of the study's progress. The tool(s) may be slightly different at each organization, e.g., per the different component(s) being implemented. (The data to be collected through the data collection tool may need to be approved by OMB, e.g., through a generic clearance.)

Within one month of approval by the COR(s) of an organization as a site in an evaluation, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) the evaluation monitoring plan for that organization, including an evaluation monitoring tool(s), and **shall submit revisions within two weeks of receipt of comment**. The Contractor shall be prepared to update the monitoring plan **annually** to reflect changes and ensure adherence, if required.

Task 8: Data Archiving

It is possible that data collected will not be sufficient to warrant data archiving, or appropriate for data archiving: for example, data may include only transcripts of private interviews. In such cases or others, the COR(s) may waive this task and its deliverables.

It is also possible that data archiving will be necessary, for example because of the usefulness of data for other researchers, or in order to transfer data from the in-depth case studies to another entity who will build on them. In such cases or others, the COR(s) will direct the Contractor to execute this task and its deliverables.

Subtask 8.1: Data Archive and Transfer Plan

ACF is interested in making data and analyses supported through federal funds available to other researchers, including other organizations who may carry on this research. The Contractor shall develop and submit to the COR(s) a plan for providing ACF with all materials that would be needed to replicate the findings of any analyses conducted in this services component or add new data within the datasets developed. The contractor's plan shall reflect the most efficient methods of information and data storage for ACF (e.g., provide ACF with electronic files where possible).

Well in advance of archiving, the Contractor shall submit a draft data archive and transfer plan that:

- establishes procedures and parameters for all aspects of data/information collection (e.g., informed consent, data maintenance, etc.) necessary to support archiving information and data collected under the contract; and
- if necessary, transfers all data collection and analysis procedures to another entity.

Topics to be addressed in the plan include, but are not limited to:

- identification of appropriate data archive(s) for the subject matter, data, and analysis files;
- communication plan with the archiving entity;
- identification of the types of data expected to be collected and methods that will support the archiving of each type;
- inclusion of consent form language that accurately represents any plans to share or transfer data to other researchers as well as to store collected containing PII and data linkages for longer-term preservation;
- identification, justification, and procedures for handling collected data that would not be archived (e.g., proprietary measures, lower quality data, etc.);
- methods of data storage to support archiving;
- data and analyses file construction and documentation that will support data archiving and duplication of all analyses;
- procedures to ensure data are prepared in accordance with archive requirements (e.g., documentation requirements, level of masking, etc.);
- considerations of the level of restriction and access for different types of data;
- the schedule for archiving different types or waves of data;
- development of a data training plan to help researchers and other interested groups with which to actively engage use the archived data; and

- procedures for reviewing and updating the plan to ensure it reflects and addresses changes over time in types of data collected or other changes.

The Contractor shall produce as many data files as are requested by the COR(s). Final disposition of complete data, including personally identifiable and/or sensitive information, with appropriate levels of security should also be addressed in the plan and is subject to approval by the COR(s).

In creating all data files, the Contractor shall plan to:

- employ masking and other strategies as appropriate to ensure the confidentiality and privacy of the sample members is ensured;
- prepare and deliver tables that describe each variable contained in the data files and include information such as frequencies and means;
- prepare and deliver documentation to accompany the files that describe how to use and access the file and any editing strategies employed;
- include all data from major project deliverables in common word processing, spreadsheet, and/or graphics formats as agreed upon by the COR(s); and
- ensure compliance with all requirements imposed by Federal statutes concerning the collection and maintenance of data which includes personal identifiers in order to satisfy the privacy and confidentiality provisions of the Privacy Act, Social Security Act, and the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA).

With regard to archiving, the Contractor shall plan to explore outside sources available to archive project data to allow use by other researchers and shall present recommendations to the COR(s). As agreed by the COR(s), the contractor shall ensure that public/restricted use files are prepared in a manner consistent with the requirements of the government and the archiving organization. The ultimate disposition of the data files created during the course of the study will be determined by ACF. The Contractor shall plan to respond to requests from the archive to produce data in the form/format required for public/restricted use. ACF experience suggests that 3-7 months may be required before staff at the archive completes their review of the data. The archive staff may seek additional information from the contractor during this period. The contractor shall include a timeline in their archiving plan for when they expect to deposit the data with the archive.

With regard to transfer, the contractor shall include in its plan processes for a smooth transition of the information gained under this contract to the COR(s), or other HHS agent, including other organizations under contract to HHS. This includes materials including all files, software, architecture, programming, codes, analysis tools, databases, measures, forms, reports, search engine features, and all other features and supporting documentation prepared for or purchased as part of this contract. The contractor shall provide all software, databases, interfaces, measurement tools, and data under a no-cost, no-strings license to another in case this contract is terminated.

The plan shall also discuss costs associated with the data archive and transfer.

Within one month after submitting any OMB package, the contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a data archive and transfer plan (or shall update an existing one) and shall submit revisions **within two weeks** of receipt of comment.

Task 9: Special Topics

The Contractor may be asked to address topics of special interest to ACF through research and analyses, convening experts, or undertaking special activities on special topics related to the study area as requested by the COR(s). This task may include the production of short reports (about 20 pages) and/or briefs (about 4-5 pages) on topics of interest. The topics of these reports may involve project data or other data/information.

The COR(s) may identify the topics and output(s) (e.g., reports/briefs); or, the Contractor may recommend to the COR(s) topics to be considered and output(s). The COR(s), with input from other Federal staff and officials, will make the final determination about topics and output(s).

The Contractor may perform the following activities for each topic authorized under this task:

- Meet and consult with the COR(s) and other Federal staff, as appropriate, for initial discussion and guidance on topic and obtain approval from the COR(s) to undertake work on the topic;
- Submit a draft plan 30 days after ACF agrees on the topic, and a final detailed plan two weeks after receipt of comment, for undertaking the work involved, including focus, data sources, timeline, outline and table shells (if appropriate), to the COR(s) for discussion and approval; and
- Submit a report/brief on the schedule approved by ACF, and a revised report/brief two weeks after receipt of comment.

These activities may be performed on a timeline developed by the Contractor and accepted by the COR(s) for each report/brief.

Task 10: Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Clearance for Data Collection and Institutional Review Board (IRB) Approval

Subtask 10.1: OMB Generic Clearance

If necessary to accomplish the goals of the project, the Contractor shall develop an OMB package related to one of ACF's Generic Clearances and shall allow at least 45 days for the clearance process (from the time of ACF approval of generic clearance package). Federal Register notices are not required.

For generic clearance packages, the Contractor shall submit a draft OMB justification package (including data collection instruments) to the COR(s) for review and approval no later than three (3) months prior to when data collection is expected to begin. After the Contractor makes any changes recommended by the COR(s), ACF will submit the final package to OMB. The contractor shall address comments received from OMB and revise materials as needed until approval is received from OMB

Subtask 10.2: OMB Full Clearance

The Contractor may be asked to prepare the required Federal Register Notices (FRNs) and information collection request materials for submission to OMB as directed by the COR(s), allowing at least 300 days for the clearance process (to include ACF review through OMB approval). The timing of this package may be discussed during the initial project discussion (Task 1). The Contractor shall submit draft instruments and 30- and 60-day FRNs to the COR(s) for review and approval on a schedule determined by the COR(s). After the Contractor makes any changes recommended by the COR(s), ACF will submit the FRNs and instruments to ACF and HHS leadership for review. The Contractor shall submit a draft OMB justification package to the COR(s) for review and approval on a schedule determined by the COR(s). After the Contractor makes any changes recommended by the COR(s), ACF will submit the final package to OMB. The Contractor shall address comments received from OMB as directed by the COR(s) and revise materials as needed until approval is received from OMB.

Subtask 10.3: IRB Approval and Certificate of Confidentiality

Institutional Review Board (IRB) approval is needed to ensure that human subjects are protected. If needed, the Contractor will submit draft IRB materials to the COR(s) for review no later than four (4) weeks before materials are due to the firm's IRB. The schedule for submission of these materials shall be determined in discussion with the COR(s).

The Contractor shall seek a Certificate of Confidentiality from the National Institutes of Health if appropriate and shall note this in the OMB package as needed. The Contractor shall provide ACF a copy of the Certificate or approval, as well as any materials submitted. If appropriate, ACF may require the Contractor to submit draft materials before they are submitted to NIH. As part of their proposal for the Certificate of Confidentiality, the Contractor must have approval from an IRB.

Task 11: Privacy and Data Security Activities and Monitoring

ACF is committed to ensuring that Controlled Unclassified Information (CUI) are appropriately maintained consistent with applicable laws and regulations until the point that it is destroyed according to the most recent versions of National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication (SP) 800-88 required by HHS/ACF. This includes, but is not limited to: Executive Orders; Privacy Act of 1974; Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA); Federal Information Security Management Act of 2002 (FISMA); Freedom of Information Act of 1974; Federal Records Management Act; NIST SPs; OMB Circulars and Memoranda; Government Accounting Office (GAO) guidance; HHS/ACF Rules and Guidance; and Department of Defense's Defense Intelligence Security Agency Security Technical Implementation Guide (DISA STIG) Hardening Guidelines. To meet this expectation, the Contractor shall undertake appropriate activities to maintain the confidentiality, integrity, and availability of all CUI. This includes (a) following the relevant policies, procedures, controls, and standards required by the HHS/ACF Information Security Program and (b) using any applicable templates, policies, forms, and other agency documents.

Depending on the type and nature of the CUI collected (determined in conjunction with the COR(s) and after review of the Privacy Impact Assessment (PIA) or equivalent document), the Contractor may be required to store the CUI in an environment that requires an Authority to Operate (ATO). If the Contractor does not have an environment with an ATO, but is determined to need one, they shall plan to secure one and include this information in the **data security plan**

(DSP), including alternative options, and submit it to the COR(s) on a schedule determined after the PIA or equivalent document has been completed. The Contractor should choose the most efficient and effective method in consultation with the COR(s) and related ACF staff.

As directed by the COR(s), the Contractor shall complete the privacy, security, and related trainings required by HHS/ACF, then provide to the COR(s) the certificates of completion for each training. This may include Contractor Information Security Awareness, Privacy, and Records Management training.

Based on the type and nature of CUI this contract may involve, the Contractor may be required to store the CUI in an environment that requires an Authorization to Operate (ATO). The COR(s) may not be able to determine whether an ATO is required until after the Contractor provides a PIA or equivalent document and/or data security plan in the Base 1, Task 8. Should the Contractor be required to secure an ATO, the Contractor shall coordinate with ACF to obtain one within a schedule approved by the ACF OCIO no later than 30 days after contract award to achieve compliance with HHS/ACF standards. ACF anticipates the process for completing the ATO to be 6 months.

This ATO shall require the Contractor to achieve and maintain compliance with the recent versions of the following documents as required by HHS/ACF: NIST SP 800-18; FIPS 199; FIPS 200; NIST SP 800-53; DISA STIG; SP 800-171; OMB Memorandum M-05-22; and other applicable NIST, HHS, and ACF policies and guidance.

Contractors must provide the following deliverables in accordance with a schedule approved by ACF Tech:

- System Security Plan (SSP) - Overview of system security controls, updated annually.
- Security Assessment Plan/Report (SAP/SAR) - Assessment results, updated annually.
- Interconnection Security Agreement (ISA) - Documents security responsibilities for system interconnections.
- Plan of Action and Milestones (POA&M) - Tracks and mitigates security risks, updated quarterly.
- Contingency Plan - Developed and tested annually.
- E-Authentication Questionnaire - Ensures appropriate authentication levels.

Refer to Attachment 8 for more information related to Zero Trust Architecture.

OPTIONS

In addition to the services outlined above, ACF may elect to exercise any or all of the options outlined below at any time during the period of performance.

OPTION 1

Period of Performance: 18 months

Purpose: The Contractor shall engage in a range of activities to: (1) finalize proposed study design and conceptual model(s), (2) develop data collection materials, and (3) finalize study site recruitment and selection.

End Products of Value:

- A public-facing report summarizing key aspects of the design including refined details about core components to be tested, research questions, conceptual model(s), study sites, study participants, and data sources.

The Contractor shall be responsible for:

Task 1: Project Management and Team Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as the Base Task 1 and will not be repeated here.

Task 2: Revise and Implement Active Engagement Approach

To accomplish the goals of including meaningful and appropriate active engagement while upholding the principle of independence in ACF-sponsored research and evaluation studies, there should be a clearly articulated rationale for the Contractor's approach to active engagement to guide the entire project and achieve its purpose. The Contractor's approach should be intentional in working with other contractors and related projects to coordinate technical assistance and support to grant recipients. These contractors include but are not limited to providers of programmatic, local evaluation, or federal research and evaluation technical assistance to HMRF grant recipients. The revised Active Engagement Plan (Subtask 2.1) should also include discussion of how the project will undertake collaboration and coordination in a way to further support the HMRF learning agenda.

Subtask 2.1: Revised Active Engagement Plan

The Contractor shall revise the plan developed under the Base for active engagement in project tasks and deliverables.

The Contractor shall submit a revised plan to the COR(s) **on a schedule determined with the COR(s)** and a final deliverable to the COR(s) **within three (3) weeks of receiving ACF feedback.**

Subtask 2.2: Implementation of Active Engagement Activities

The description of this subtask and its associated deliverables is the same as Base Subtask 3.2 (Implementation of Active Engagement Activities) and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 3: External Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as the Base Task 4 and will not be repeated here with the exception of Subtask 3.1.

Subtask 3.1: Revise Project Description

The Contractor shall revise the project description developed under the Base on a **schedule proposed by the contractor and approved by the COR(s).** The Contractor shall update the

project description over the course of the contract at the request of the COR(s) to ensure that the project description adequately provides up-to-date information about the project.

Task 4: Update and Refine Research Design Plan

The Contractor shall refine the research design and update the plan developed under the Base Subtask 5.3 to reflect any ongoing decisions and updates. The Contractor shall submit a revised plan to the COR(s) **on a schedule determined with the COR(s).**

Task 5: Data Collection

Subtask 5.1: Recruit and Train Data Collectors

For each evaluation, the Contractor shall develop a plan for recruiting data collection staff and for comprehensive training to ensure that they have the necessary skills to perform their duties. All persons who collect or have access to raw data must be trained in confidentiality issues, complete any mandatory trainings, and provide signed assurances of nondisclosure of confidential information. Additionally, the Contractor shall conduct background checks of personnel prior to being permitted to work on the project and every 5 years after in compliance with the Fair Credit Reporting Act. This is a requirement for all contractor/subcontractor employees working on this contract that may have contact with or manage information regarding vulnerable populations, children, and/or youth in their homes or programs. These individuals include but are not limited to, data collectors, on-site coaches, trainers, etc. In addition, the proposed hire shall complete a “Basic Criminal History and Statement of Admission” during this background check and then annually update if anything has changed in their history that might change the results of their background check. This information shall be provided to the designated CO and COR(s) if the result adversely impacts suitability. See additional information in Section 5 “Background Checks.”

The plan shall include a strategy for training data collectors, including a timeline and location(s) of training.

At a minimum of three months prior to data collection for each evaluation, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a short memorandum detailing a data collection training plan and shall submit revisions **within two weeks** of receipt of comment.

Following approval of each training plan, the Contractor shall conduct thorough training of all individuals involved in research and data security protocols, as well as training program staff in their roles in inputting information into the data collection tool. The training shall be completed before data collection efforts begin.

As a means of quality control, **at least one month** prior to training data collectors for each evaluation site, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) the written outline of each training session, and copies of all training materials. The outline shall include:

- A program agenda that identifies the formats to be used to conduct the training, the topics to be covered, and the length of the training;
- An outline of the materials that trainees will be provided;

- The Contractor's plan for evaluating the training program and the performance of individual trainees including achieving and maintaining adequate inter-rater reliability; and
- A schedule that identifies when and where the training will occur.

The Contractor shall submit revisions **within two weeks** of receipt of comment.

Upon receipt of approval of data collector training/materials, the contractor shall conduct the training. The Contractor shall provide all facilities and materials for training of data collection staff, and for assuring that all staff successfully complete the training specified in the training plan. In the event that some training may have to be provided across multiple organizations, the training program must be designed in such a way that standardization of training is assured, across locations, as well as over time.

Subtask 5.2: Develop and Refine Data Analysis Plan

The Contractor shall develop a data analysis plan for each evaluation design. Each analysis plan shall include, but is not limited to: measurement issues (e.g., how to use survey results to measure key outcomes), methods issues (multiple comparison problem, regression adjustment), recommendations for pre-specifying primary and secondary outcomes (at each data collection point), any anticipated challenges in the analysis of each research question, the appropriateness of pooling data across some or all organizations vs. analyzing organizations separately, and other topics (e.g., relevant sub-groups). For all data sources (e.g., surveys, observations, interviews, etc.) the Contractor shall identify the specific types of data analyses that will be employed for each data element, including unit of analysis, possible aggregations, method of display and specific research questions that will be addressed for each set of analyses.

Within 2 months of approval of data collection instruments and protocols for an evaluation design, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a memorandum outlining a data analysis plan for each evaluation design and shall submit revisions **within two weeks of receipt of comment**.

Subtask 5.3: Register Study

ACF values transparency in research and evaluation. To that end, the Contractor shall register the study with an appropriate registry prior to the initiation of data collection. Some examples include: clinicaltrials.gov, Open Science Framework, What Works Clearinghouse registration, etc. Contractors are encouraged to also pre-specify their analysis plan, if appropriate. The Contractor shall submit draft and final registration materials to the COR(s) for review and approval prior to registering the study. These materials shall be submitted and updated on a schedule proposed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s).

Subtask 5.4: Begin Data Collection

According to the approved refined research/evaluation design and the approved data collection instruments and protocols, the Contractor shall collect data (or oversee collection of data). Each type of data collection (related to process evaluation or impact evaluation) shall begin as soon as possible/necessary following receipt of notice of OMB approval.

The Contractor shall implement procedures for managing and monitoring adherence to data collection protocols (quality, completeness, etc.) and obtaining high responses from the full research sample to follow-up surveys or other information collection (i.e., 80%).

The Contractor shall recommend and undertake corrective actions needed to achieve high response rates.

The Contractor shall report to the COR(s) on a **regular basis progress or issues related to data collection by site**. In monthly progress reports, the contractor shall include tables detailing progress on the data collection efforts, including especially response rates and costs compared to estimates.

Task 6: Site Selection

Subtask 6.1: Finalize Agreements with Selected Programs/Organizations

Finalize the Memoranda of Understanding (MOU) agreements that were drafted and shared under the Base period. Conduct any necessary follow-up and review to finalize MOUs with selected sites **within two (2) months of the organization being approved** for inclusion and sufficiently in advance of the proposed study start date. The Contractor shall inform participating organizations that ACF must review and approve each negotiated MOU before it is formally signed by both the Contractor and the organization's authorized representative.

Subtask 6.2: Evaluation Monitoring and Support for Each Site

Following the approved evaluation monitoring plan developed in Subtask 7.3 of the Base, the contractor shall implement and closely monitor evaluation operations, provide appropriate feedback to program officials to assist them in meeting goals and objectives, and assess evaluation-related issues in each organization on a regular basis.

According to the MOU established with each organization, the contractor shall provide the necessary financial support to meet evaluation requirements and/or to deliver program services.

On conference calls and in monthly progress reports, **the contractor shall submit regular updates** to ACF on organization operations and progress compared to benchmarks along with the agenda for discussion during the regular calls (once per month) and shall summarize organization progress/challenges and contractor actions in written monthly progress reports.

Subtask 6.3: Technical Assistance

The Contractor shall identify and/or develop necessary materials for organizations:

- To successfully implement programming related to the component(s) to be tested; and
- To support the specific evaluation approach (e.g., scripts for staff, curricula, staff training, evaluation TA, etc.)

In addition to materials, the contractor shall also update/develop new procedures and methods to assess ongoing organizational implementation of the component(s) or of evaluation support requirements, identify performance problems or issues, and provide assistance to correct

problems (e.g., track enrollment performance in relation to agreed-upon targets, ensure appropriate distinction between treatment and control services, quality and completeness of staff data entry, avoid cross-overs, etc.).

Within two weeks of identifying the need for materials or updated/new procedures/methods, or upon a schedule agreed upon with the COR(s), the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a memorandum with versions of materials and/or updated/new procedures/methods, and shall submit revisions **within two weeks** of receipt of comment.

Task 7: Data Archiving

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 8 (Data Archiving) and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 8: Interim Report

The Contractor shall create a public-facing report summarizing each test, that is, the components being tested, the research questions, the evaluation designs, the sites, the analyses, and anticipated timeline for results. The purposes of this document are (1) to inform the public of the credible vitality of the components and their corresponding conceptual models being evaluated, and the importance of evaluating them, and (2) to ensure the public is aware of tests.

Within 10 months following election of the optional services component, the Contractor shall submit the interim report and shall submit revisions **within two weeks** of receipt of comment. For any public-facing contract deliverables or dissemination products, the Contractor shall assume at least four rounds of review.

Task 9: Special Topics

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 9 and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 10: OMB and IRB Clearance

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 10 (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Clearance for Data Collection) and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 11: Ongoing Privacy and Data Security Activities and Monitoring

The Contractor shall adhere to the statements made in the PIA or equivalent document developed according to Services Component 1, Task 11. If the Contractor is not required to complete and maintain an updated System Security Plan, they also shall adhere to the procedures outlined in the Data Security Plan developed in Services Component 1, Task 11. The Contractor shall follow these procedures and statements for all data activities included as part of this optional services component. The Contractor shall update the DSP developed in Base Task 11, **as needed but not less than annually**.

If the Contractor is not required to complete and maintain an updated System Security Plan, they shall submit an annual report that outlines their compliance with the DSP developed for the project. In this report, the Contractor shall discuss the data activities undertaken during the year and document how these data activities have adhered to the DSP, as well as any issues or challenges that arose in doing so over the year, including any incidents and the remediation. In addition, the annual report shall include any audit reports and vulnerability scans necessary to validate that the planned security controls are in place. The Contractor shall submit the annual report on compliance with the DSP **no later than thirteen (13) months after the plan was approved and annually thereafter.**

As directed by the COR(s), the Contractor shall complete the privacy, security, and related trainings required by HHS/ACF, then provide to the COR(s) certificates of completion for each training. This may include Contractor Information Security Awareness, Privacy, and Records Management training.

OPTION 2

Period of Performance: 15 months, this option may be exercised up to two (2) times

Purpose: The Contractor shall engage in a range of activities to implement the study as designed.

End Products of Value:

- A public-facing interim report summarizing key aspects of the study design and study progress.

The Contractor shall be responsible for:

Task 1: Project Management and Team Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC1 Task 1 and will not be repeated here. The task shall focus on the goals and activities of this Services Component.

Task 2: Revise and Implement Active Engagement Approach

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC1 Task 2 and will not be repeated here. The task shall focus on the goals and activities of this Services Component.

Task 3: External Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Task 3 and will not be repeated here.

Task 4: Update and Refine Research Design Plan

The Contractor shall refine the research design and update the plan to reflect any ongoing decisions and updates. The Contractor shall submit a revised plan to the COR(s) on a schedule determined with the COR(s).

Task 5: Data Collection

Subtask 5.1: Update and Refine Data Analysis Plan

The Contractor shall refine each evaluation design, as necessary, based on the specific site(s) selected for each evaluation and in alignment with approved data collection plans, instruments, and protocols. At a minimum, the Contractor shall consider:

- Revisions to sample size;
- Approaches to sample recruitment and retention; and
- The cost implications of the approved data collection approach, as well as any proposed alternatives.

The Contractor shall update and refine the Data Analysis Plan, as needed, to reflect any changes to evaluation design or data collection activities. Updates shall be completed according to a schedule determined in consultation with the COR(s).

Subtask 5.2: Continue Data Collection

According to the approved refined research/evaluation design, and the approved data collection instruments and protocols, the Contractor shall collect data (or oversee collection of data). Each type of data collection (related to process evaluation or impact evaluation) shall begin as soon as possible/necessary following receipt of notice of OMB approval.

The Contractor shall implement procedures for managing and monitoring adherence to data collection protocols (quality, completeness, etc.) and obtaining high responses from the full research sample to follow-up surveys or other information collection (i.e., 80%).

The Contractor shall recommend and undertake corrective actions needed to achieve high response rates.

The Contractor shall report to the COR(s) on a **regular basis progress or issues related to data collection by site**. In monthly progress reports, the contractor shall include tables detailing progress on the data collection efforts, including especially response rates and costs compared to estimates.

Subtask 5.3: Data Analysis

The Contractor shall undertake analysis, per the approved research/evaluation design and data analysis plans. The Contractor shall ensure that the analysis consider appropriate quantitative data analysis, qualitative data analysis, and analysis that links the two, unless otherwise approved by the COR(s).

The Contractor shall report to the COR(s) on a regular basis progress or issues related to data analysis. In monthly progress reports, the Contractor shall include details on progress on the data analysis, including especially tables detailing interim results.

Task 6: Site Support and Oversight

Subtask 6.1: Monitor and Support for Each Site

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Subtask Task 6.2 and will not be repeated here.

Subtask 6.2: Technical Assistance

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Subtask 6.3 and will not be repeated here.

Task 7: Data Archiving

Subtask 7.1: Archive Data

The Contractor shall undertake all activities necessary to comply with the requirements of the data archiving plan developed by the Contractor and approved by the COR(s). If necessary, the Contractor may propose amendments and additions to the initial plan; the Contractor shall seek comment and approval from the COR(s) regarding any amendments or additions.

The Contractor shall prepare and deliver the final data files and documentation to be housed in data archiving entity identified (heretofore referred to as Data Archive) in the data archiving plan. The Contractor shall prepare data files and all documentation in accordance with guidelines provided by the Data Archive and approved by the COR(s). The data files must contain sufficient information to allow duplication by other researchers of all analyses prepared by the Contractor. The Contractor shall employ masking and other strategies as appropriate to ensure the confidentiality and privacy of the sample members is ensured, as it applies. The Contractor shall also prepare documentation (e.g., codebooks, user's manuals) to accompany the files that describe the following: 1) each variable on the file; 2) how to use and access the file; and 3) any editing strategies employed.

Prior to the initial data collection, the Contractor shall design, establish, and implement the procedures to transform the data into a computerized form that can be used by a variety of standard statistical software packages (e.g., SAS and SPSS for Windows). After data collection begins, the Contractor shall edit the computerized data and correct all errors until the computer files contain only verified and accurate records. If special software must be developed/utilized for data analyses, the Contractor must make this software available to the COR(s) and to the Archive for no additional charge, along with the data sets.

The Contractor shall allocate sufficient resources for preparing necessary documentation to accompany the data files, monitoring requests for clarifications and corrections as needed. The Contractor shall present information on the background and purpose of the study, the design of the study, and key measures included in the study. The Contractor shall also present information necessary for proper use of the data, including (but not limited to) information on the structure of the data files, key variables necessary for conducting analyses, information on the use of sample weights, and information on appropriate methods for addressing design effects in the study.

The Contractor shall respond to requests from the Data Archive to produce data in the form/format required for public/restricted use. The Data Archive staff may seek additional information from the Contractor during this period. The draft data file and all documentation must be delivered to the Data Archive for review in accordance with a schedule negotiated with the Data Archive that allows sufficient time for review and any necessary Contractor revisions

based on review by the Data Archive staff. It is expected that the final data files and documentation shall be delivered to the Data Archive **upon a schedule agreed upon with the COR(s)**.

Task 8: Interim Report

The Contractor shall develop a public-facing interim product that provides meaningful updates on study progress to the field. The product may take the form of a report or other dissemination format, as approved by the COR(s), and shall synthesize key information about the study. This may include, but is not limited to, descriptions of the components being tested, research questions, evaluation designs, participating sites, implementation experiences, analytic approaches, and anticipated timelines for results. The product may also include summaries of early findings, implementation insights, or cross-site observations, as appropriate to the stage of the study.

The purpose of this product is to (1) communicate timely and relevant information about the study to stakeholders and the broader field, including the significance of the components and approaches being tested, and (2) increase awareness and understanding of ongoing evaluation activities and their potential contributions to evidence-building.

Within 10 months following election of the optional services component, the Contractor shall submit the interim product, and shall **submit revisions within two weeks of receipt of comments**. For any public-facing deliverables, the Contractor shall assume at least four rounds of review.

Task 9: Special Topics

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 9 and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 10: OMB and IRB Clearance

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 10 (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Clearance for Data Collection) and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 11: Ongoing Privacy and Data Security Activities and Monitoring

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 11 and will not be repeated here.

Task 12: Transition of Materials

All products developed as a result of work completed under this requirement become the sole property of the government and shall be provided to the COR(s) at the termination of the requirement period. **At least twelve (12) months** prior to the end of the task order, the Contractor shall submit to the COR(s) a plan for transitioning work products to ACF (**see deliverables table**).

The Contractor shall assure a smooth transition of the information gained under this requirement to the COR(s), or other agent. This includes all materials such as files, software, architecture, programming, codes, analysis tools, forms, reports, and all other features and supporting documentation prepared for or purchased as part of this requirement. The Contractor shall provide training to ACF staff and others designated by the COR(s) to facilitate smooth transfer of operations so that ACF is able to manage the operation of any deliverables after the task order ends. The Contractor shall provide all materials and any necessary training to the COR(s) and/or others designated by the COR(s) **at least three (3) weeks** prior to the end of the task order (see **deliverables table**).

OPTION 3

Period of Performance: 13 months

Purpose: The Contractor shall engage in a range of activities to: (1) complete the study as designed, (2) produce final report of study findings, (3) prepare materials for dissemination.

End Products of Value:

- A public-facing report on impact study findings.

The Contractor shall be responsible for:

Task 1: Project Management and Team Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC1 Task 1 and will not be repeated here. The task shall focus on the goals and activities of this Services Component.

Task 2: Revise and Implement Active Engagement Approach

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC1 Task 2 and will not be repeated here. The task shall focus on the goals and activities of this Services Component.

Task 3: External Communication

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Task 3 and will not be repeated here.

Task 4: Data Collection

Subtask 4.1: Continue Data Collection

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 2 subtask 5.2 and will not be repeated here.

Subtask 4.2: Data Analysis

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 2 subtask 5.3 and will not be repeated here.

Task 5: Site Support and Oversight

Subtask 5.1: Monitor and Support for Each Site

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Subtask Task 6.2 and will not be repeated here.

Subtask 5.2: Technical Assistance

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 1 Subtask 6.3 and will not be repeated here.

Task 6: Data Archiving and Transfer

Subtask 6.1: Archive Data

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 2 Subtask 7.1 and will not be repeated here.

Task 7: Final Report

The Contractor shall develop one final report per core component studied. Each final report should summarize the findings from that core component. In addition, the Contractor shall write a short report summarizing the methodology, knowledge gained, and implications for the field.

The Contractor shall submit a draft outline of the final report **within six months following election of the optional services component**. Upon receipt of comment, the Contractor shall submit a **revised draft outline within two weeks**. The Contractor shall submit the final report draft **within 6 months of approval of draft outline**. Upon receipt of comment, the Contractor shall submit a **revised draft within two weeks**. For any public facing contract deliverables or dissemination products, the Contractor shall assume at least four (4) rounds of review, which includes review by project-level staff those in various levels of leadership ACF as directed by the COR(s).

Task 8: Special Topics

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 9 and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 9: OMB and IRB Clearance

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 10 (Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Clearance for Data Collection) and will not be repeated here. The task shall be focused on the goals and activities to this Services Component.

Task 10: Ongoing Privacy and Data Security Activities and Monitoring

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as Base Task 11 and will not be repeated here.

Task 11: Transition of Materials

The description of this task, including subtasks and associated deliverables, is the same as OSC 2 Task 12 and will not be repeated here.

4.0 Additional Security Requirements

3.1: IT Security Requirements

3.1.1: Contractor Onboarding Requirements

Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD)-12

The Contractor must comply with the following policies and standards related to Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD)-12, federal security requirements, and Federal Acquisition Regulations (FAR):

1. HSPD-12, Policy for a Common Identification Standard for Federal Employees and Contractors
2. OMB Memorandum M-05-24, Implementation of Homeland Security Presidential Directive (HSPD) 12
3. Federal Information Processing Standard (FIPS 201-3), Personal Identity Verification (PIV) of Federal Employees and Contractors
4. Executive Order 13467, Part 1 §1.2, Reforming Processes Related to Suitability for Government Employment, Fitness for Contractor Employees, and Eligibility for Access to Classified National Security Information
5. FAR Subpart 4.13, Personal Identity Verification
6. FAR Subpart 52.204-9, Personal Identity Verification of Contractor Personnel
7. Federal Information Security Management Act (FISMA)

Position Sensitivity Designations

The Contractor must undergo a background investigation based on the position sensitivity designation, as outlined in Title 5, Chapter IV Code of Federal Regulations (CFR), Parts 1400 and 731. The background investigation must be successfully adjudicated before the Contractor

accesses government systems and information. The sensitivity levels applicable to this contract can be determined using the Position Designation Tool.

The Contract Office Representative(s) (COR(s)) will inform the Contractor of the required investigation level for each staff member. For new positions, the Contractor must provide a position description, and the Government will determine the appropriate sensitivity level.

The Contractor must submit a roster of all staff working under this contract who will develop, access, host, or maintain government information systems. The roster must include

- Name
- Position
- Email address
- Phone number
- Responsibilities

The roster must be submitted to the COR and/or Contracting Officer (CO) **within 3 days of the contract's effective date**. Any updates due to staffing changes must be submitted **within 24 hours of the change**.

Cybersecurity Training

The Contractor must become familiar with all the departmental security policies published in the HHS Information Security and Privacy Program. The guidelines within the program are based federal laws, regulations, and standards. As such, the contractor must adhere to all policies.

The Contractor must complete mandatory training before they are cleared to work on the contract. Both the Cybersecurity Awareness Training and the Rules of Behavior must be completed before government furnished equipment is provided to the Contractor. The training can be accessed at the Security Awareness and Training website.

The Contractor must also complete Role-Based Training (RBT) in accordance with HHS policy if it is determined that their role has significant security responsibilities. After onboarding, the Contractor must complete all cybersecurity training annually and updated annually or upon the government's request. Training records must be submitted to the COR(s), or designated representative, within 30 days of contract award.

3.1.2: Baseline Security Requirements

These requirements apply to contracts that allow the Contractor access to government information, whether physical or electronic, or operate federal systems containing data that support ACF's mission. These systems include IT systems, computers, peripherals, software,

services, and related resources as defined in FAR Subpart 2.1, Definitions. Access to government information or systems is contingent upon a favorable background check.

Safeguarding Information

Government information and systems must be protected according to Federal Information and Information Systems (FIPS) 199, Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems, standards for confidentiality, integrity, and availability.

- Confidentiality - Prevent unauthorized access and disclosure, including personal and proprietary information.
- Integrity - Prevent improper modification or destruction, ensuring authenticity and non-repudiation.
- Availability - Ensure timely, reliable access to information.

To comply, the Contractor must:

- Secure systems connected to HHS networks or operated on behalf of ACF.
- Implement HHS Information Security Program policies, procedures, and controls to protect confidentiality, integrity, and availability.
- Comply with Privacy Act requirements and tailor FAR clauses as needed.
- Store and maintain data within U.S. borders unless explicitly authorized by ACF Tech to enforce data sovereignty.

Compliance with HHS ACF Access Control

The Contractor must adhere to the ACF Access Control Policy (ACF-OCIO-2020-0001) to protect information from unauthorized access and ensure proper segregation of duties when using the application for administrative or general purposes.

Information Security Categorization

The Contractor must work with ACF security representatives to categorize information and systems based on FIPS 199, Standards for Security Categorization of Federal Information and Information Systems, and National Institute of Standards and Technology Special Publication (NISTSP) 800-60 guidelines and implement appropriate controls based on the determined categorization. Categorization determines risk levels (low, moderate, high) for confidentiality, integrity, and availability, and may change during the system lifecycle.

Control Unclassified Information (CUI)

The Contractor, including Software as a Service (SaaS) providers, must comply with Executive Order 13556, Controlled Unclassified Information, when handling CUI. CUI is information that requires safeguarding or dissemination controls under laws, regulations, or policies, such as Personally Identifiable Information (PII) and Protected Health Information (PHI).

- Disclose only to authorized personnel on a need-to-know basis.
- Protect per NIST SP 800-53, Security and Privacy Controls for Information Systems and Organizations (if handled by a contractor system operated for the agency) or NIST SP 800-171, Protecting Controlled Unclassified Information in

Nonfederal Systems and Organizations (if handled by internal contractor systems).

- Return, destroy, or retain CUI as directed, following NIST SP 800-88 guidelines for media sanitization.

Sensitive Information

Sensitive information refers to data that requires protection from unauthorized access or disclosure due to its potential to cause harm to individuals, organizations, or national interests if compromised. It includes PII, PHI, and CUI. In compliance with Office of Management and Budget (OMB) Memorandum M-06-16, Protection of Sensitive Agency Information, the Contractor must secure sensitive information, using encryption solutions validated under FIPS 140-3, Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules, to prevent unauthorized access.

Confidentiality and Non-disclosure of Information

The Contractor is responsible for safeguarding the confidentiality of government records and must inform employees and subcontractors about the confidentiality requirements in writing, utilizing a formal Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA). Information provided by ACF or collected on ACF's behalf by the contractor must be used solely to fulfill the contract. This information must not be disclosed to anyone except as necessary for contract performance. An NDA must be signed by each employee and sub-contractor and provided to the government upon demand.

Unauthorized disclosure is subject to HHS/ACF sanctions and the following laws:

- **18 U.S.C. 641** Criminal Code – Public Money, Property, or Records
- **18 U.S.C. 1905** Criminal Code – Disclosure of Confidential Information
- **44 U.S.C. Chapter 35, Subchapter I** Paperwork Reduction Act

Incident response

The Contractor must follow ACF's Incident Response Policy.

In the case of a suspected or confirmed incident or breach, the Contractor must:

1. **Protect sensitive information** (including PII) created, stored, or transmitted under this contract to prevent further incidents.
2. **Notify affected individuals** only as directed by the Contracting Officer or their representative.
3. **Report all incidents** (suspected or confirmed) to the ACF Incident Response Team (IRT), COR, CO, and other stakeholders. This includes incidents involving PII in any form (paper, oral, or electronic), as outlined in ACF's Incident Response Policy.
4. **Cooperate fully** with the Government during incident response activities. This includes providing requested data (e.g., images, logs, event details) and implementing measures such as disconnecting affected systems or applying additional security controls. If hosting

services are provided, physical access to contractor facilities may be required during investigations.

3.1.3: Digital Services

Internet Protocol Version 6 (IPv6)

The Contractor must comply with the mandate to transition to IPv6 to meet federal requirements for modernized and secure internet protocol usage. According to OMB Memorandum M-05-22, Transition Planning for Internet Protocol Version 6 (IPv6), the strategic intent of the Federal government is to deliver its information services, operate its networks, and access the services provided by others using only 2.2.1 Internet Protocol Version 6 (IPv6). OMB Memorandum M-21-07, Completing the Transition to Internet Protocol Version 6, released in 2020, updates the original guidance and provides agencies with information to help overcome any barriers preventing the migration to a IPv6-only infrastructure.

Government Websites

The Contractor must ensure that all public-facing websites developed, maintained, or supported under this contract comply with OMB Memorandum M-23-22, Delivering a Digital-First Public Experience. This includes prioritizing user-centered design, accessibility, and mobile responsiveness in alignment with the 21st Century Integrated Digital Experience Act (21st Century IDEA). The Contractor must support agency efforts to streamline websites, digitize paper-based processes, and enhance online self-service capabilities, while adhering to standards for accessibility and cybersecurity. All public-facing websites must use HTTPS with HTTP Strict Transport Security (HSTS) enabled and must avoid insecure redirects and downgrade attacks. While HTTPS is not mandatory for internal-facing websites, its use is strongly recommended.

Requirements

1. Consistent Appearance - Must maintain a consistent appearance throughout.
2. Redundancy - Must not mirror or overlap with other websites.
3. User-Centered Design - Must be designed using agile methodology to effectively meet requirements.
4. Customized Experience – Must offer options for users to have a personalized experience.
5. Mobile-Friendly – Must be fully operational on standard mobile devices.
6. Availability - Must ensure there is no service disruptions during the transition-in or transition-out periods.

These guidelines ensure that the new or redesigned website is user-friendly, secure, and accessible to everyone.

Standard for Encryption

The Contractor must implement encryption controls to protect government information from unauthorized access, in accordance with the Department of Health and Human Services (HHS)

and Administration for Children and Families (ACF) standards. Specifically, the Contractor must:

- Comply with the HHS Standard for Encryption to prevent unauthorized access to government data.
- Encrypt all government data in transit and at rest—including on servers, storage devices, mobile devices, and backup media—using FIPS 140-3, Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules validated encryption, in accordance with the Cryptographic Module Validation Program (CMVP).
- Secure all devices (e.g., desktops, laptops, and mobile devices) used to store or process government data, ensuring compliance with HHS and ACF encryption requirements.
- Maintain a current inventory of all devices and media that store sensitive government information, including Personally Identifiable Information (PII).
- Use only encryption solutions validated under FIPS 140-3, Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules, and provide validation documentation to the COR(s) prior to implementation.
- Utilize the HHS PIV Key Management system or implement a key recovery mechanism that allows authorized personnel to encrypt, decrypt, and recover encryption keys.
- Provide all encryption keys to the COR(s) upon request and at the conclusion of the contract.
- Encrypt all government data using FIPS 140-3, Security Requirements for Cryptographic Modules validated methods to ensure compliance with the most current ACF Tech encryption standards.

3.2: Records Management and Retention Policy

1. Compliance with Records Laws and Policies

The Contractor must comply with all applicable records management laws and regulations, including the Federal Records Act (44 U.S.C. Chapters 21, 29, 31, and 33), National Archives (NARA) regulations (36 CFR Chapter XII, Subchapter B), and applicable policies regarding the protection of records under the Privacy Act of 1974 (5 U.S.C. § 552a). This includes preserving all records—regardless of format, transmission method, or completion status. In the event of a conflict, NARA policies take precedence over ACF policies.

2. Definition and Management of Federal Records

In accordance with 36 CFR § 1222.32, all data created for Government use, delivered to the Government, or under its legal control are Federal records. Such records are subject to applicable statutes, including Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) (5 U.S.C. § 552) and the Privacy Act, and must be managed and scheduled for disposition as required by law and regulation.

3. Contractor Responsibilities for Recordkeeping

The Contractor must manage all records created in the performance of this contract or delivered to the Government in accordance with Federal law and regulation. Electronic records must

include sufficient technical documentation and associated metadata to ensure proper understanding and use.

4. Protection Against Unauthorized Destruction

The Contractor and ACF are responsible for preventing the unauthorized removal, defacing, alteration, or destruction of records, including by mutilation. Records may not be destroyed or removed from ACF custody except in accordance with approved records schedules and with written authorization from the Head of the Contracting Activity. Violations are subject to penalties under 18 U.S.C. § 2701. Any actual or suspected loss or destruction of records must be reported immediately to ACF, which will notify NARA per 36 CFR § 1230.

5. Safeguarding Information and Records

The Contractor must notify the Contracting Officer immediately upon discovery of any unauthorized disclosure or compromise of Government records, data, or equipment. Non-public information may only be disclosed to authorized individuals with a need-to-know. The Contractor must implement appropriate administrative, technical, and physical safeguards to protect such information. Material may not be removed from Government or Government-operated facilities or systems without written approval from the Head of the Contracting Activity. Upon completion or when no longer needed, materials must be returned to ACF or held pending further direction. Delivery must be made securely by hand, mail, email, or other secure means as directed. Destruction of records is strictly prohibited unless authorized under paragraph 4.

6. Subcontractor Disclosure Requirements

The Contractor must obtain Contracting Officer approval before entering into any subcontract that involves disclosure of information or records generated under this contract. All subcontractors must comply with applicable Government and ACF policies on sensitive, proprietary, classified, or controlled unclassified information.

7. Use of Government IT Resources

The Contractor must use Government IT systems and equipment solely for purposes authorized by the contract and in accordance with ACF policy.

8. Creation of Non-Public Records

The Contractor must not create or retain any records containing non-public ACF information unless such records are explicitly authorized by the contract.

9. Restrictions on Use of Protected Information

The Contractor must not retain, use, sell, or distribute any deliverables containing Privacy Act-protected or otherwise exempt information unless authorized by law.

10. Government Ownership of Records and Data

ACF retains full ownership and unlimited rights to all records and data created or delivered under this contract. The government may use, disclose, or dispose of such data as it deems

appropriate. Any Contractor rights must be disclosed as required by FAR 52.227-11 through 52.227-20.

11. Records Management Training

All Contractor personnel who create or handle Government records must complete ACF-provided records management training, including initial, annual, and refresher training as required. The Contractor is responsible for ensuring compliance with this requirement.

3.3: Accessibility and Section 508 Standards

3.3.1: Section 508 and Accessibility Standards

The Contractor must comply with Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act, as amended by the Workforce Investment Act of 1998 (P.L. 105-220), which requires that all Information and Communications Technology (ICT) must be accessible to individuals with disabilities. Federal agencies must ensure that individuals with disabilities (both internal and external) have access to information and services equivalent to access provided to individuals without disabilities. This requirement applies to all ICT purchased, built, maintained, or used by the federal government, including products and services acquired via federal purchase cards.

The Contractor must present a fully completed Accessibility Conformance Report (ACR) using the Voluntary Product Accessibility Template (VPAT) (available at <https://www.itic.org/policy/accessibility/vpat>) for each proposed product, platform, or service. The government will evaluate the VPAT on an Acceptable/Unacceptable basis. If the product or service does not conform to ACF Section 508 requirements, the Contractor must remediate the product or service, at no additional cost to the government, before acceptance.

3.3.2: Section 508 ACF Acquisition Regulation Clauses

To comply with the 352.239-73(B) Electronic and IT Accessibility Notice the following provision must be included:

Electronic and Information Technology Accessibility Notice (DEC 2015)

- a. Under Section 508 of the Rehabilitation Act of 1973, as amended, and 29 U.S.C. 794d, all ICT products and services developed, acquired, maintained, or used under this contract must align with the "Electronic and IT Accessibility Provisions" issued by the Architectural and Transportation Barriers Compliance Board (Access Board).
- b. The specific Section 508 standards applicable to this contract are identified in the PWS. The contractor is required to submit written Section 508 Conformance Certifications that are accurate and validated by testing. The government may perform testing to ensure compliance. Non-compliance will require remediation at the contractor's expense.
- c. For contract modifications or additional ICT deliverables, contractors must submit an updated VPAT to validate accessibility compliance. Tools and testing

deliverables must meet the standards provided in the HHS Product Assessment Template or equivalent federal resources.

To facilitate compliance, contractors must meet the following obligations:

Submission Requirements - Contractors must submit Section 508 Conformance Checklists provided by ACF for all deliverables. The CO will specify the timeline for submission.

Remediation Requirements - Contractors must promptly remediate non-compliant items identified by government reviews.

Continuity of Compliance - Ensure that ICT products meet WCAG Levels A and AA on an ongoing basis and remain supported throughout the contract lifecycle.

Failure to submit timely and compliant deliverables may impact the continuation of the contract, including options or funding approval. Resources for compliance are available at:

- ACF Section 508
- [HHS Section 508 Compliance Policy](#)

3.3.3: References for Accessibility Compliance

- [Section 508 Standards](#)
- Training DHS Section 508 Training
- OMB M-24-08 OMB M-24-08
- [Web Content Accessibility Guidelines WCAG](#)

5.0 Background Checks

- The Contractor shall conduct background checks of personnel prior to being permitted to work on the project and every 5 years after in compliance with the Fair Credit Reporting Act. This is a requirement for all contractor/subcontractor employees working on this contract that may have contact with or manage information regarding vulnerable populations, children, and/or youth in their homes or programs. These individuals include but are not limited to, data collectors, on-site coaches, trainers, etc. In addition, the proposed hire shall complete a “Basic Criminal History and Statement of Admission” during this background check and then annually update if anything has changed in their history that might change the results of their background check. This information shall be provided to the designated CO and COR(s) if the result adversely impacts suitability. Contractors are strongly encouraged to set up [Rap Back systems](#) to receive automatic alerts if information on a currently employed individual changes in-between formal checks. Background checks shall include at minimum FBI Next Generation Information (NGI) criminal history repository and National Crime Information Center (NCIC) National Sex Offender Registry (NSOR) checks. All criminal history checks must use fingerprints if that is an option and otherwise can be name based. o

- Disqualifying offenses include, but are not limited to:
 - Refusal to consent to background check
 - Knowingly making a materially false statement in connection with such criminal background check
 - Is registered, or is required to be registered, on a state sex offender registry or repository, or the National Sex Offender Registry
 - Has been convicted of a felony consisting of murder, spousal abuse, child abuse or neglect, crime against children, including child pornography, crime involving rape or sexual assault, kidnapping, arson, physical assault or battery or drug related offenses.
 - Has been convicted of a violent misdemeanor committed as an adult against a child, including the following crimes: child abuse, child endangerment, sexual assault, or of a misdemeanor involving child pornography.
- Should the background check indicate a positive result for any of the sources, the contractor shall notify the designated CO and COR(s) within 2 business days for determination of suitability. In addition, the contractor shall investigate the nature of the offense, the age of conviction, and the time since the offense occurred and provide a written justification if the intent is to move forward with having the individual work on the project.
- The strictest standard shall be used for individuals engaged in direct in-person data collection or fieldwork that may encounter vulnerable populations, including adults where children may be present, children, youth or other vulnerable populations and managing information about such vulnerable populations.
- Contractors must complete the full background check process and review prior to the individual's initiating work on the contract. Contractors may provisionally staff a prospective staff member on the project after receiving the results of the fingerprint-based FBI criminal history check. These individuals must be accompanied by fully vetted and cleared supervisory staff on all field assignments until the full background check is completed, especially in situations where children or youth may be physically present.

6.0 Contractor Quality Assurance

The Government intends to utilize a Quality Assurance Surveillance Plan (QASP) to monitor the quality of the Contractor's performance for the life of the contract. In addition to the general oversight provided in the contract, the QASP will provide performance metrics help to ensure that service levels reach and maintain the required levels throughout the contract term. Further, the QASP provides the COR(s) with a proactive way to avoid unacceptable or deficient performance and provides verifiable input for the required Past Performance Information Assessments. The QASP is a living document and may be updated as necessary for the life of the contract.

The Contractor shall review the attached QASP (Attachment 6) and shall submit comments within 30 calendar days after order award for COR(s) review. The contract's performance requirements are dictated by the QASP.

7.0 Table of Deliverables

Table 1: List of Deliverables

TBD

Notice to contractors:

All information and data related to this project that the contractor gathers or obtains will be both protected from unauthorized release and considered the property of the government. The contracting officer will be the sole authorized official to release verbally or in writing any data, draft deliverables, final deliverables, or any other written or printed materials pertaining to this contract.

Press releases, marketing material, or any other printed or electronic documentation related to this project must not be publicized without the written approval of the contracting officer.

8.0 Required Travel and Other Direct Costs (ODCs)

Travel and Other Direct Costs (ODCs) shall be built into the into the contract price and will not be separately reimbursed.

9.0 Government Furnished Property/Equipment/Information

The Government will provide any additional information necessary to meet all deliverables described herein, including access to Government resources such as SharePoint, Microsoft programs, and anything else needed for successful performance. Materials such as reports, manuals, and publications will be provided as required.

10.0 Glossary of Abbreviations and Acronyms

ACF	Administration for Children and Families
CO	Contracting Officer
COR	Contracting Officer's Representative
FAR	Federal Acquisition Regulation
FISMA	Federal Information Security Management Act of 2002
FRN	Federal Register Notice
GAO	Government Accountability Office
HHS	Department of Health and Human Services
HIPAA	Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act

HMRF	Healthy Marriage and Responsible Fatherhood
IRB	Institutional Review Board
ODC	Other Direct Cost
OFA	Office of Family Assistance
OMB	Office of Management and Budget
OPRE	Office of Planning, Research, and Evaluation
PIA	Privacy Impact Assessment
PII	Personally identifiable information

11.0 Key Personnel

Project Director - The Project Director is the main point of contact between the government client and the contracting organization and is responsible for the strategic direction and successful delivery of the contract.

Responsibilities:

- Provides strategic oversight for local evaluation support.
- Manage relationships with key stakeholders, including government officials, clients, and senior leadership within the organization.
- Take responsibility for the overall performance of the contract, including meeting deadlines, staying within budget, and ensuring compliance with regulations.
- Ensures that data-driven decisions align with OFA's monitoring needs, requirements laid out in the HMRF Notice of Funding Opportunities announcements, and federal requirements.

Experience Needed:

- Ideally 8-10 years or more of experience in managing large-scale projects, with a strong focus on high-value or government contracts.

Skills Needed:

- Strategic Thinking & Decision-Making
- Knowledge and experience providing local evaluation technical assistance
- Leadership & Stakeholder Management
- Knowledge of Data Compliance & Regulations
- Risk Assessment & Quality Control
- Financial Acumen & Budget Management
- Knowledge of formatting or overseeing finished products for public release (e.g., publishing briefs or reports for federal government agency clients)
- Management experience, including direct management and contract oversight responsibilities

Deputy Project Director - The Deputy Project Director is the secondary point of contact between the government client and the contracting organization and is responsible for the strategic direction and successful delivery of the contract.

Responsibilities:

- Provides support for strategic oversight for local evaluation support.
- Helps manage relationships with key stakeholders, including government officials, clients, and senior leadership within the organization.
- Assists the Project Director in ensuring the overall performance of the contract is high quality, including meeting deadlines, staying within budget, and ensuring compliance with regulations.
- Provides guidance to support data-driven decisions align with OFA's monitoring needs, requirements laid out in the HMRF Notice of Funding Opportunities announcements, and federal requirements.

Experience Needed:

- Ideally 5-7 years or more of experience in managing large-scale projects, with a strong focus on high-value or government contracts.

Skills Needed:

- Strategic Thinking & Decision-Making
- Knowledge and experience providing local evaluation technical assistance
- Leadership & Stakeholder Management
- Knowledge of Data Compliance & Regulations
- Risk Assessment & Quality Control
- Financial Acumen & Budget Management
- Knowledge of formatting or overseeing finished products for public release (e.g., publishing briefs or reports for federal government agency clients)
- Management experience, including direct management and contract oversight responsibilities